Partisanship in Local Bureaucratic Appointments: Evidence from Election Administration*

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Abstract

Party-affiliated officials make thousands of appointments for local bureaucratic positions each year. To what extent are they structuring those decisions in a partisan way? In this paper, I examine partisanship in the appointment of election officials. I combine original panel data of local election officials and partisan appointing authorities across 18 states, hundreds of jurisdictions, and over 20 years. Employing difference-in-differences and non-parametric matching estimators, I find that principals are about 50% more likely to appoint an election official that matches their party affiliation than one who does not. The effect is especially strong when Republicans come to power and is driven by both replacement of the previous election official and inducement for them to change party allegiance. However, local partisan selection falls far short of national-level partisanship, is most likely in politically uncompetitive climates, and does not degrade the quality of election administration. The results show the limited nature of partisan polarization in local politics as well as the resilience of U.S. election administration in the face of partisan pressures.

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1 Introduction

One of the biggest questions in local American politics is the extent to which it resembles national politics (Anzia 2021; Hopkins 2018). Recent work answers this question by examining the behavior of voters (Conevska et al. 2024; Kuriwaki 2026) and elected politicians (de Benedictis-Kessner and Warshaw 2016, 2025; Ferrer, Geyn, and Thompson 2024; Thompson 2020). Largely unexamined is partisan polarization in local appointments. We elect a small number of people relative to the total number of government officials, to whom we delegate the appointment of the vast majority of those officials (Brierley et al. 2023). Therefore, appointments are one of the most important mechanisms by which partisan polarization can affect our democracy. To what extent are local politicians structuring those decisions in a partisan way?

Classic public administration models of bureaucracy highlight a strict demarcation between the spheres of politics and administration, with politicians deciding policy and bureaucrats implementing those policies (Goodnow 1900; Wilson 1887). A large body of research shows this as an ideal rather than a reality. Politicians prefer ideologically similar agents (Bendor, Glazer, and Hammond 2001; Brehm and Gates 1999) and select bureaucrats for their partisan allegiance rather than their managerial competence (Aberbach, Putnam, and Rockman 1981; Bach and Veit 2018). In the U.S., Presidents are expected to select appointees who are politically loyal and supportive of their agendas (Lewis 2008, 2011; Mann 1964). Their influence reaches to career civil servants (Clinton, Lewis, and Selin 2014), leading to increased turnover among those with divergent political views (Bertelli and Lewis 2012; Bolton, de Figueiredo, and Lewis 2020). However, the evidence for partisanship in appointments by state and local officials is much more mixed: scholars have identified partisan pressures in the selection of city managers (McCabe et al. 2008) and public university presidents (Rutherford, Rabovsky, and Santiago 2025), but not school superintendents (Mellon 2025).

Furthermore, there is disagreement over the normative implications of partisanship in bureaucratic appointments. The traditional view is that partisan considerations come at the expense of competence, degrading the quality of administration (Bauer et al. 2021; Cameron and de Figueiredo 2020; Krause, Lewis, and Douglas 2006; Lewis 2007, 2008; Spenkuch, Teso, and Xu 2023). Alternatively, partisan selection can be viewed as an important component of appointments to ensure democratic responsiveness. Because it is not feasible for people to vote for every office, they delegate elected politicians to select appointees who are qualified and responsive (Ferrer 2025; Rehmert 2022). Furthermore, a desire for conformity may lead co-partisans to better constrain the actions of bureaucrats (Palus and Yackee 2016).

This paper studies the actions of officials who appoint local election officials across the United States. Where election officials' principals are directly tied to party labels, how do they use their authority to shape who the county's election administrator is, and does partisan influence reduce the quality of officials' work? I combine panel data on local election officials and voter file records with original data of principals partisanship from 2002 to 2024, across 867 jurisdictions spanning 18 states. Employing a series of difference-in-differences and matching estimators, I find that Democratic election officials are much more likely to be appointed when Democrats come to power, compared with under Republican control. In my main estimates, the effect is about 50 percent of the baseline rate of Democratic election officials. The effect appears to be driven by Republicans selecting for co-partisans when they come to power and is caused by both turnover of the election official and inducement for incumbent official to change party allegiance. Partisan influence appears strongest in politically uncompetitive districts. It does not appear to have grown stronger over time, and shifts in principal partisanship do not cause noticeable changes in observable indicators of election administration. This paper advances our understanding of partisanship in local bureaucratic appointments as well as the resilience of the U.S. system of election administration in the face of partisan pressures.

2 Partisanship in the Appointment of Public Officials

Political appointment of bureaucrats is as old as the system of democracy itself. Even if voters have a say in who represents them, it is infeasible for voters to directly elect all of the officials needed to carry out the necessary functions of government. Scholars disagree on how open the bureaucracy should be to political influence. On the one hand, accountability flows through the actions of directly elected officials. When voters elect a politician, they expect them to appoint officers who will carry out their agenda. Partisan influence, in this sense, can ensure appointed officials are qualified and responsive to the needs of voters (Ferrer 2025; Rehmert 2022). Co-partisan appointees might find themselves more constrained in their actions than out-partisans due to their desire for party conformity (Palus and Yackee 2016), and partisan patronage networks can effectively connect voters with government services (Toral 2024).

On the other hand, appointments may serve to shield bureaucrats from partisan pressures. Progressive Era reforms at the turn of the 20th century sought to protect public officials from partisan politics by handing the reins of hundreds of city governments to unelected city managers (Bertelli and Lynn 2006). Indeed, switching to appointments can lead to better performance. Judges facing electoral pressure tend to render more punitive judgments than those who do not (Gordon and Huber 2007; Huber and Gordon 2004), elected municipal assessors exacerbate inequality in property taxation (Sances 2016), elected city treasurers increase borrowing costs (Whalley 2013), and elected local election officials administer elections with lower turnout and longer wait times (Ferrer 2025).

Bureaucratic independence can be viewed as a principal-agent problem, where the goals of principals conflict with those of their appointed agents (Hassan, Larreguy, and Russell 2024; Hood and Lodge 2006; Hood 1991; Pollitt and Bouckaert 2017). In this sense, it is important to protect officers against politically motivated dismissal from rent-seeking politicians and who seek to impose efficiency-undermining political pressures (Horn 1995; Miller 2000). Most recent studies in developed democracies have found a negative link between political

influence and bureaucratic output (Cameron and de Figueiredo 2020; Krause, Lewis, and Douglas 2006; Lewis 2007, 2008; Spenkuch, Teso, and Xu 2023).[1] Populist party influence in bureaucracy can even contribute to democratic backsliding (Bauer et al. 2021).

Insulation from partisan pressures might be particularly beneficial in election administration. Nonpartisan election administration is desired by large majorities of the public across both parties (Stewart 2021). Election integrity is vital to a well-functioning democracy, and partisan interference or the appearance of partisan actors can significantly reduce voters' confidence in election results (Norris and Grömping 2019). Previous scholarship has found that election officials who are directly elected administer elections similarly regardless of party affiliation (Ferrer, Geyn, and Thompson 2024) and that election officials who are appointed by partisan actors do not appear to produce election results favoring their principals' party (Ferrer 2025). However, partisan principals could still attempt to shape election outcomes by replacing election administrators appointed by previous out-partisan principals or pressuring them to make decisions favorable to the party. Hiring and firing decisions made with regard to partisan preference rather than ability could result in lower quality election administration. It could also contribute to high turnover rates in the profession, which have grown by 50% over the past 25 years (Ferrer and Thompson 2025).[2]

2.1 How Do Principals Exert Political Influence on the Bureaucracy?

Principals could use their appointment authority to achieve partisan ends in two ways. First, according to the "Ally Principal", they may seek partisan gain by choosing an agent that informally matches their declared party affiliation (Brehm and Gates 1999; Epstein and O'Halloran 1999). Previous studies have found that employers make hiring decisions based

[1] Studies of patronage in developing countries similarly tend to find negative effects on development (Akhtari, Moreira, and Trucco 2022; Colonnelli, Prem, and Teso 2020; Geddes 1994; Xu 2018).

[2] Recent news reports suggest that at least some jurisdictions experience turnover of election officials due to partisan principals. `https://www.washingtonpost.com/dc-md-va/2023/11/02/lynchburg-elections-registrar-lawsuit/`

on the political affiliation of applicants (Gift and Gift 2015; Roth et al. 2020) and that judges are selected based on their ideological beliefs (Bonica and Sen 2017, 2021). In cases where the currently serving agent was appointed by previous principals of a different party affiliation, the principal could dismiss them or refuse to renew their appointment. Second, principals could influence the actions of their agent by issuing the threat of dismissal or making the working conditions of the appointee difficult.[3] This requires the willingness of the agent to alter their administrative decisions and the ability of the principal to effectively monitor the actions of their agent. The change in party control could also induce the bureaucrat to change party allegiances to match their new principal. Geys et al. (2025) finds evidence of bureaucratic partisan malleability in state governments; the same could be true of local bureaucrats.

Principals may be constrained in pursuing partisan actions by laws, by other veto players, and by institutional norms (Horn 1995; Miller 2000). In the first case, statute can prohibit public officials with appointment authority from removing an agent from their position prior to the end of their term without cause or make such an action exceedingly difficult. For instance, Texas statute states that county elections administrators may be terminated "at any time for good and sufficient cause", but it requires a four-fifths vote of the three-member county election commission and the subsequent approval by a majority vote of the county commissioners court (TX Elec Code § 31.037 (2024)). In North Carolina, the procedure for removal requires the county board of elections to state the reasons for termination and the approval of the Executive Director of the State Board of Elections, whose decision can be deferred by the State Board of Elections. The county elections director is provided an opportunity to reply to the petition and plead their case before the state board. However, states such as Georgia and Pennsylvania have no statutory protections for their appointed election directors. Appointees can sue for wrongful termination due to their partisan affiliation. Courts have interpreted the First Amendment as prohibiting a public agency from

[3] https://www.texastribune.org/2023/04/17/heider-garcia-tarrant-county-elections-tim-ohare/

discharging employees based on their political affiliation if they serve in positions that are neither policymaking nor advisory.[4] In practice, the burden of proof is high for such cases. Second, multiple principals may be involved in the appointment decision (Spiller and Urbiztondo 1994; Whitford 2005). This creates the possibility for principals with strong partisan desires to be overruled, as a majority must agree on the appointment (Rutherford, Rabovsky, and Santiago 2025; Tsebelis 1999). This may prove less of a barrier with increased partisan polarization (Forand, Ujhelyi, and Ting 2022). Finally, even if principals have the formal authority and the institutional capacity to exert authority for partisan gain, they may choose not to do so to maintain institutional norms of nonpartisanship. Norms are the weakest barrier to action, but politicians may adhere to them by selecting a consensus appointment or maintaining the previous party's appointment because by doing so, they reduce the likelihood that out-partisans will break the norm when they gain power (Miller 2000).

2.2 Why Might Partisan Principals Replace Election Officials Appointed By The Previous Party?

Why might a change in the majority party control of appointing bodies increase the likelihood that they select a co-partisan election official? One explanation is that principals make party-minded appointment decisions with the goal of altering election administration in ways that benefit their co-partisans at the ballot box. However, previous research has found this not to be the case. Directly elected Democratic and Republican election officials, serving in comparable jurisdictions, oversee elections with similar election administration outcomes (Ferrer, Geyn, and Thompson 2024). Additionally, changes in the partisan composition of election boards do not appear to affect partisan electoral outcomes (Ferrer 2025). This could simply be due to strong selection effects of who wants to be a local election official. Similar to police chiefs (Johnson 2005), sheriffs (Thompson 2020), and school superintendents (Bjork

[4]See Gibbons v. Gibbs, No. 23-1902 (4th Cir. 2024) and Goodman v. Pa. Tpk. Comm'n, 293 F.3d 655, 663 (3rd Cir. 2002).

and Kowalski 2005), incoming local election officials tend to have relevant prior experience in government or elections (Ferrer and Thompson 2025). Additionally, as with district attorneys (Sances 2021), election officials tend to have less polarized views on their policy area than the general public (Manion et al. 2021). Alternatively, election officials may try to act in ways that benefit their partisan principals but fail to move the needle due to the resilience of the election system (Ferrer, Geyn, and Thompson 2024; Grimmer and Hersh 2024).

This leaves two possibilities: principals could replace the old election official due to their perception that their chosen official will make different administrative decisions, or they could do so to reward co-partisans even if they do not expect an effect. In the former case, principals could view their appointment authority as a legitimate and relatively low-cost way to maximize their chances of winning and maintaining party control. This could also be a defensive move. Perhaps newly empowered principals are distrustful of their predecessor's motives, and hire a new election official to ensure an equal playing field at the polls. In short, they prefer an ally at the helm (Bendor, Glazer, and Hammond 2001; Brehm and Gates 1999). In the latter case, principals may view the post as a potential source of old-fashioned patronage, rewarding party loyalists or political supporters with a government job (Brierley et al. 2023; Calais-Haase and Rogowski 2021). Both explanations could be at play. Especially given rising levels of affective polarization (Abramowitz and McCoy 2019; Iyengar et al. 2019), co-partisans' growing antipathy to out-partisans may lead them both to distrust prior principal's decisions and prefer a friendly agent. Rather than untangle these explanations, here I seek to uncover the extent to which principals are making decisions based on partisanship and whether this degrades the quality of election administration.

3 Data and Methods

In order to study partisanship in election official appointments, I collect panel data on the party of appointed election officials and the party of their principal authorities. Both are

collected at biennial intervals covering even-year November federal elections. For the former, I draw on data from Ferrer and Thompson (2025). I estimate the party identification of appointed officials using exact and fuzzy matching with historical voter file data from L2. Details of this dataset and the matching procedure can be found in Section A.1 of the online appendix.

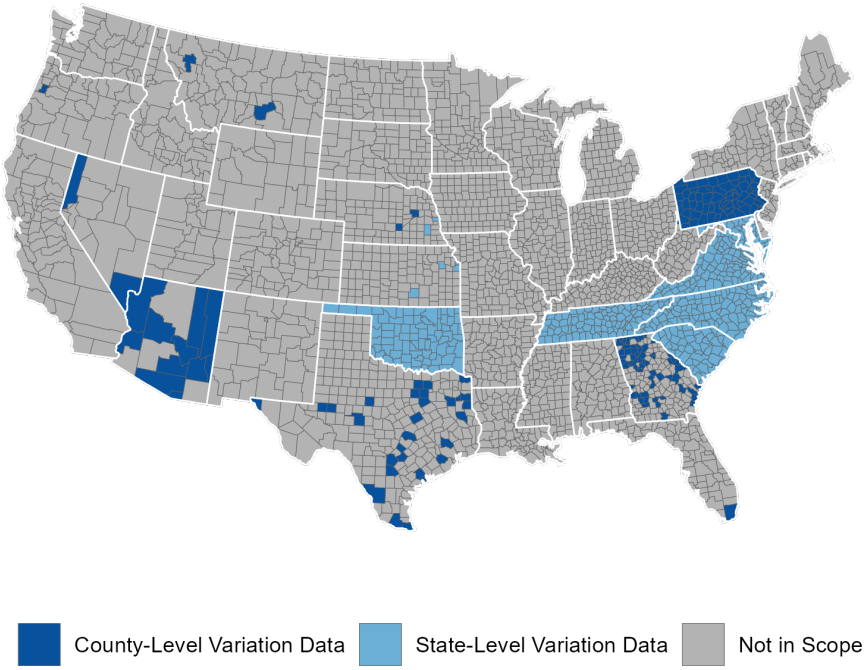
I identify all election jurisdictions administered at the county level that select their chief local election official through appointment by partisan officials. Appointed local election officials run elections for more than half of all voters in the U.S. and for 39% of all election jurisdictions (Ferrer and Geyn 2024). Of these, I collect data on the 867 counties across 18 states and DC where appointed election officials have been selected by principals with official partisan affiliation at least once between 2002 and 2024. The principals have party affiliations in one of three ways: direct election with party labels, appointment by someone who is themselves elected with party labels, or appointment by party officials.[5] Many counties have changed their method of selecting a local election official over the past two decades (Ferrer 2025). Of the 867 counties, 659 had continuous partisan appointments between 2002 and 2024. I have complete panel data for every county that meets these criteria.[6]

Figure 1 shows which counties continuously selected their election official via partisan appointment between 2002 and 2024. The specifics of partisan local election official appointments vary widely, but can be grouped into two categories by the geography of variation: those whose party balance is determined at the state level, and those whose party balance is determined at the county level. More details on the structure of appointing bodies can be found in Section A.2. The data on partisanship of appointing officials was obtained from a variety of sources, including election results, archived state and local government websites,

[5] I exclude jurisdictions where officials are appointed by politicians elected without party labels. This applies to at least some counties in California, Hawaii, Minnesota, and Oregon. Delaware, New Jersey, New York, and Ohio are excluded because election officials are appointed by evenly split bipartisan boards.

[6] Only jurisdictions that administer elections at the county level are included in this study. At least some municipalities in Massachusetts, Maine, Michigan, Rhode Island, Vermont, and Wisconsin use partisan principals to appoint their chief local election officials. These states are not included in the analysis due to a lack of panel coverage of their appointment structures.

Figure 1: **Map of Included Jurisdictions in the United States**. This map displays which counties are in the data analysis and vary at the county-level (dark blue), which counties are in the analysis and vary at the state-level (light blue), and which counties are not in the project's scope (grey). Counties eligible for analysis are those with partisan appointment of their chief local election official continuously between 2002 and 2024. Counties are out of scope either because their local election official is not appointed by partisan principals or because primary election responsibilities are carried out by municipal actors. Alaska's election jurisdictions vary at the state-level and Hawaii's are not in scope.



newspaper articles, and direct communication with local officials. Tables A.2 and A.3 in the online appendix provide descriptive statistics on in- and out-of-sample counties and on county-level vs. state-level variation jurisdictions, respectively. In-sample counties tend to be more populous and more racially diverse than counties not studied, but they are similar in terms of partisanship, income, and average election official turnover.

I estimate the effect of Democratic control of the principal authority on the propensity for the appointed official to be Democratic. I use both difference-in-differences and non-parametric matching strategies. In the former cases, I construct regressions of the form

$$Y_{it} = \alpha_i + \delta_t + \beta \, \text{AppointPartyDem}_{it} + \varepsilon_{it}$$

where Y_{it} is whether the local election official is Democratic-affiliated in jurisdiction i at election year t, α_i and δ_t are jurisdiction and year (or year-by-state) fixed effects, respectively, and $Appoint_party_change_{it}$ is a dummy variable taking 1 when the appointing authority is Democratic-controlled and 0 when it is not. β is the causal effect of interest. This estimation strategy accounts for unit- and common time-specific confounders. It produces causally valid inferences under the parallel trends assumption, which requires that changes in the party of the appointed election official in jurisdictions that undergo a switch in principal partisanship would have stayed on the same trend as in jurisdictions that retain the same principal partisanship under the counterfactual where principal partisanship did not switch.

The assumption may not hold if counties that are becoming more conservative (liberal) see a transition in both their county leadership and their local election official towards Republican (Democratic) affiliation. To test the robustness of the results, I conduct non-parametric matching analyses in the spirit of Imai, Kim, and Wang (2018) that match counties on pre-treatment partisan patterns in appointing authority control and election official affiliation. I also conduct heterogeneity tests to identify where and when partisan selection is greatest. I subset the data by the direction of party switch, board authority, district and state competitiveness, county population, county importance in determining state election outcomes, racial diversity, and decade. Finally, I also use both difference-in-differences and matching analysis to test the effects of principal party change on election administration quality. I measure five observable indicators of performance: voter turnout, residual vote, and reporting errors from David Leip's Election Atlas; and provisional vote and absentee ballot rejection rate from the U.S. Election Assistance Commission's EAVS dataset.

4 Descriptive Evidence of Partisan Influence in Election Official Selection

Are principals more likely to appoint election officials that match their party than those who do not? Table 1 shows the descriptive patterns of election official and appointing body partisanship. On average, local election officials and principals match their party affiliation only 52% of the time. However, they are much more likely to be co-partisans than out-partisans. Among county-years where Democrats control the appointment of election officials principals, in 46% of cases the local election official is Democratic and in 36% of cases the local election official is Republican. Among county-years where Republicans control appointments, the local election official is a fellow Republican in 57% of cases compared with just 30% of the time when the official is a Democrat.

Table 1: Party of Election Official by Prinicipal Authority Control

	Party of Appointed Election Official				
	Democratic	Ind/NP	Republican	Unknown	Total
Democratic	1268 (48.4%)	440 (16.8%)	910 (34.8%)	1374	3992
Even/Other	69 (29.0%)	9 (3.8%)	160 (67.2%)	127	365
Republican	978 (27.4%)	409 (11.4%)	2187 (61.2%)	2008	5582
Total	2315	858	3257	3509	9939

Note:
Cell entries report counts with row percentages in parentheses. Percentages are calculated excluding election officials with unknown party affiliation. NP stands for non-partisan affiliation and includes officials with 3rd party affiliations.

It is clear that Republican county officials are more likely to appoint Republicans as election administrators and that the same is true of Democrats. However, the magnitude of the effect is limited in comparison to with state- and federal-level partisanship. Additionally, this effect could arise solely due to the nature of geographic sorting. Even if local election officials were selected at random, we should expect principal and election official party to match more frequently than not given that most counties are either mostly Republican or

mostly Democratic. I proceed with statistical tests in the following section to examine whether the relationship holds once accounting for potentially confounding factors.

5 Statistical Evidence of Partisan Influence in Election Official Selection

Table 2 shows a series of linear probability regressions testing the relationship between principal body and election official partisanship. The first three columns include year fixed effects, accounting for common time-varying factors. In the first column, all missing election official party affiliations are imputed as non-Democratic; in the second column, these are left as missing values; and in the third and subsequent columns, the data is subset to jurisdictions with complete (non-missing) partisanship panel coverage between 2002 and 2024. The point estimate in column 1 means that counties with Democratic principal control are 14.6 percentage points more likely to have a Democratic-affiliated election official than counties without a Democratic-controlled principal—with an overall average of 23 percent of appointed election officials Democratic-affiliated in the sample. The estimated effect is similar in columns 2 and 3.

Columns 4 through 6 are difference-in-difference estimators that investigate what happens to the party of the local election official when principal party control flips. All three columns include at least county and year fixed effects. Columns 5 and 6 include year by state fixed effects to account for differential trending between states over time. Column 6 subsets to counties that either never switch party control or switch exactly once, ensuring cleaner comparisons between treated and control units in the estimation at the expense of precision (Table A.4 in the online appendix displays the demographics of counties by number of party transitions). When a county switches to Democratic control, they become much more likely to appoint a Democratic-affiliated election official. The estimated effect ranges from 9 percentage points to 26 percentage points, depending on the specification. The ef-

Table 2: **Effect of Switch in Party of Appointing Authority On Party of Appointed Election Official**

	Appointed Election Official Democratic					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Dem Principal Control	0.146	0.193	0.148	0.087	0.191	0.257
	(0.017)	(0.023)	(0.041)	(0.026)	(0.099)	(0.141)
Counties	841	761	174	174	174	62
Elections (Avg)	13	13	12	12	12	12
Observations	9574	6192	2088	2088	2088	744
Outcome Mean	0.23	0.36	0.39	0.39	0.39	0.36
County FEs	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	No
Year x State FEs	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Sample	Full	Full	Panel	Panel	Panel	Panel
Missing as 0	Yes	No	No	No	No	No
Comparisons	All	All	All	All	All	Clean

Robust standard errors clustered by county in parentheses. Panel sample limited to jurisdictions with full panel data of both principal party control and election official party affiliation, from 2002 to 2024. Missing as 0 means that unknown appointed official's parties are imputed as 0 (not Democratic) rather than left as NA. Clean comparisons means the analysis is run on jurisdictions that do not switch principal party control more than once.

fect is statistically significant at the .05 level in column 4 and significant at the .10 level in columns 5 and 6. To interpret these results more concretely, the effect of 19.1 percentage points in column 5 is against a 39% baseline rate of Democratic-appointed election officials. This means the relative increase under co-partisan control is 49%. In other words, principals are about 50% more likely to appoint an election official that matches their party affiliation than one who does not.

The results are robust to substituting Republican election officials as the dependent variable (Table A.5) and to using the Callaway and Sant'Anna (2021) estimator (Figure A.2 and Table A.6), which accounts for potential bias caused by the staggered nature of the "treatment" (a switch in partisan control of the appointing authority). However, an event study graph reveals a possible violation of the parallel trends assumption, especially for counties with Republican takeovers of the appointing body (Figure A.1 in the online

appendix). In other words, counties where Republicans came to power were already more likely to have a transition away from a Democratic-affiliated election administrator.

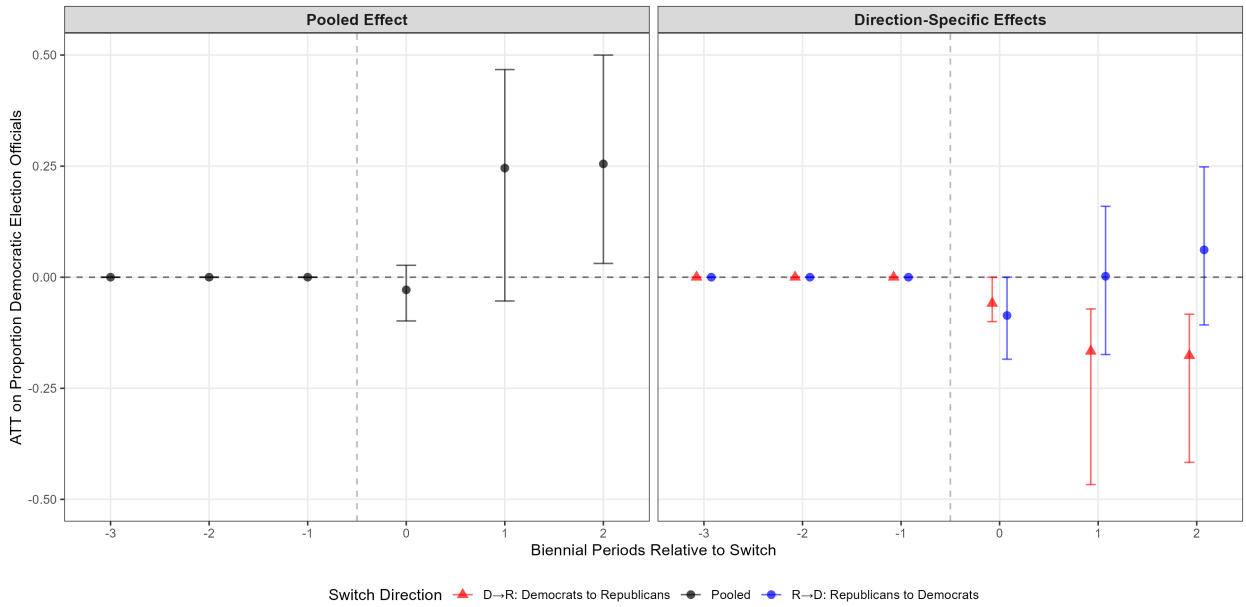
I overcome these inferential problems by limiting comparisons to counties matched on pre-treatment partisanship patterns in the spirit of Imai, Kim, and Wang (2018). I match counties within the same state that have identical patterns of principal and election official partisanship in the 3 biennial cycles prior to one of the counties switching party control. The ATT is calculated as a weighted average across all eligible years. Since three lagged matching periods requires 6 years of pretreatment data, this procedure pools results from 2008 to 2024.[7] For earlier pretreatment periods, post-treatment pooled ATTs are also calculated to create an event history, with the year of matching following treatment marked as year 0. Bootstrapped confidence intervals are calculated for each event study year and for the pooled ATT calculation. Only jurisdictions that have either Democratic or Republican majorities are included.

Figure 2 shows the results and Figure A.3 in the online appendix plots the means. Each x-axis tick is a two-year period between biennial general federal elections. The y-axis is the average treatment effect of Democratic party control on the probability that the appointed election official is Democratic-affiliated. The three pretreatment periods have ATTs of 0, showing a successful matching strategy. In the left panel, the point estimate at the first treatment period (0) is near zero and not statistically significant, indicating that Democratic principals are no more likely to appoint a Democrat to the election administrator office than non-Democratic principals in the two years following a divergence in appointing authority control. However, they are much more likely to appoint a Democratic election official in the following years. Democratic-majority principals are 25 percentage points more likely to appoint Democratic election administrators than principals that either stayed or switched to Republican control in the following biennial period. The effect persists for an additional two years and is statistically significant in the 3rd treatment period. The results are robust

[7]For instance, the 2008 treatment year uses matching pretreatment data from 2002, 2004, and 2006; the 2010 treatment year uses matching pretreatment data from 2004, 2006, and 2008; and so on.

to varying the number of pre-treatment years matched (Figures A.4 and A.5 and Table A.7 in the Online Appendix).

Figure 2: **Exact-Match Event Study ATT of Democratic Principal on Democratic Election Official**. This shows the ATT estimates produced by an exact matching procedure that matches within-state on the prior three biennial periods of principal partisanship and election official partisanship patterns. The left panel compares Democratic-controlled counties to Republican-controlled counties, pooling across all transition types. The right panel estimates direction-specific effects, comparing counties that switch from Republican to Democratic control against those that remain Republican (blue circles) and comparing counties that switch from Democratic to Republican control against those that remain Democratic (red triangles). The outcome is a binary indicator for whether the local election official is Democratic-affiliated. ATT estimates represent pooled weighted averages across outcome years. Error bars reflect 95% bootstrapped confidence intervals based on 1,000 simulations.



The right panel of Figure 2 separates the analysis by party taking control (Figure A.3 in the online appendix plots the means of this analysis). The blue circles show the effect of switching from Republican to Democratic party control on the likelihood the local election official is Democratic-affiliated, using always-Republican majority counties as the controls. The red triangles show the effect of switching from Democratic to Republican party control on the likelihood the local election official is Democratic-affiliated, using always-Democratic majority counties as the controls. The n-sizes on these tests are small, so the results should

be interpreted as suggestive rather than dispositive. That said, they are striking: a switch from Democratic to Republican party control leads to an almost 20 percentage point decline in the likelihood the appointed election official is a Democrat two years after the transition in control, but a switch from Republican to Democratic party control does not lead to any detectable change in the partisanship of the appointed election official. The findings suggest that at the local level, Republican principals prioritize selecting co-partisan election administrators while Democratic principals do not. This is consistent with work that has shown Republicans are more aggressive in influencing election policy at the state and local level than Democrats (Bentele and O'Brien 2013; Grumbach 2023).

As with the descriptive results, these findings show clear evidence of partisanship in the selection of local election officials. However, they also highlight its limits. The magnitude of the estimated effects is certainly large, but it also indicates that appointing boards frequently do not select based on party affiliation. According to column 5 of Table 2, Democratic party control of an appointing body increases the probability that the board appoints a Democratic chief election official from 40% to 59%. This is a far cry from perfect congruence between board and bureaucrat partisanship, and certainly from the levels of congruence of party appointees at the state and federal levels.

5.1 Partisan Influence Operates Through Both Replacement and Party Switching

When a new party comes to power, partisan selection of appointees can happen in two ways: they can replace the officials with co-partisans, or the incumbent bureaucrats can respond to the changing political winds by switching their party affiliation. A recent study of state-level bureaucratic elites found that only about half leave office during transitions in power (Geys et al. 2025). Those that remain tend to adjust their party identification to match their new principals.

To disentangle these competing explanations, I first examine whether turnover of local election officials increases in the wake of a transfer of power. Figure 3 plots the results of an event study using a specification similar to Column 6 of Table 2, with two modifications. Instead of Democratic party control, the outcome is a switch between Democratic and Republican party control. And instead of Democratic local election official, the independent variable of interest is election official turnover (measured as a binary over each two-year period). Tabular output is shown in Table A.8. The effect immediately following a switch in party control is small and not statistically significant. In the following biennial period, election official turnover is 23 percentage points higher in jurisdictions that experienced a change in party control compared to those that did not, a mean-sized effect that is statistically significant. This one-period gap in replacement is congruent with the delayed effect of partisan realignment shown in Figure 2.

While this confirms that replacement plays an important role, it does not tell us whether party switching among stayers also contributes to partisan alignment. To test this, I decompose the main effect of party control on election official party from Table 2 by whether the election official turned over. Table 3 uses the same two-way fixed effect specifications as columns 4 through 6 in Table 2 but separately estimates the effect of a change to Democratic control when there is turnover and when there is not turnover of the appointed official. When a Democratic principal takes control, they are more likely to appoint a new Democratic-affiliated election official and more likely to oversee the realignment of the existing officer to their party. The effects are significant at the .10 level or greater across all estimates and are substantively meaningful. In sum, partisan influence appears equally driven by replacement and party switching.

Figure 3: **Event Study Estimation of Effect of Principal Party Switch on Election Official Turnover**. This shows the effect of a switch in principal partisanship on local election official turnover relative to the number of biennial periods before or after the switch occurred. Only jurisdictions with no or a single switch in party principal control are included. Point estimates are relative to the difference in turnover between treated and control jurisdictions the period prior to principal party switch in treated counties. Effects three or more periods prior to the switch are bundled together, as are those at least four periods after the switch. Error bars reflect 95% confidence intervals.

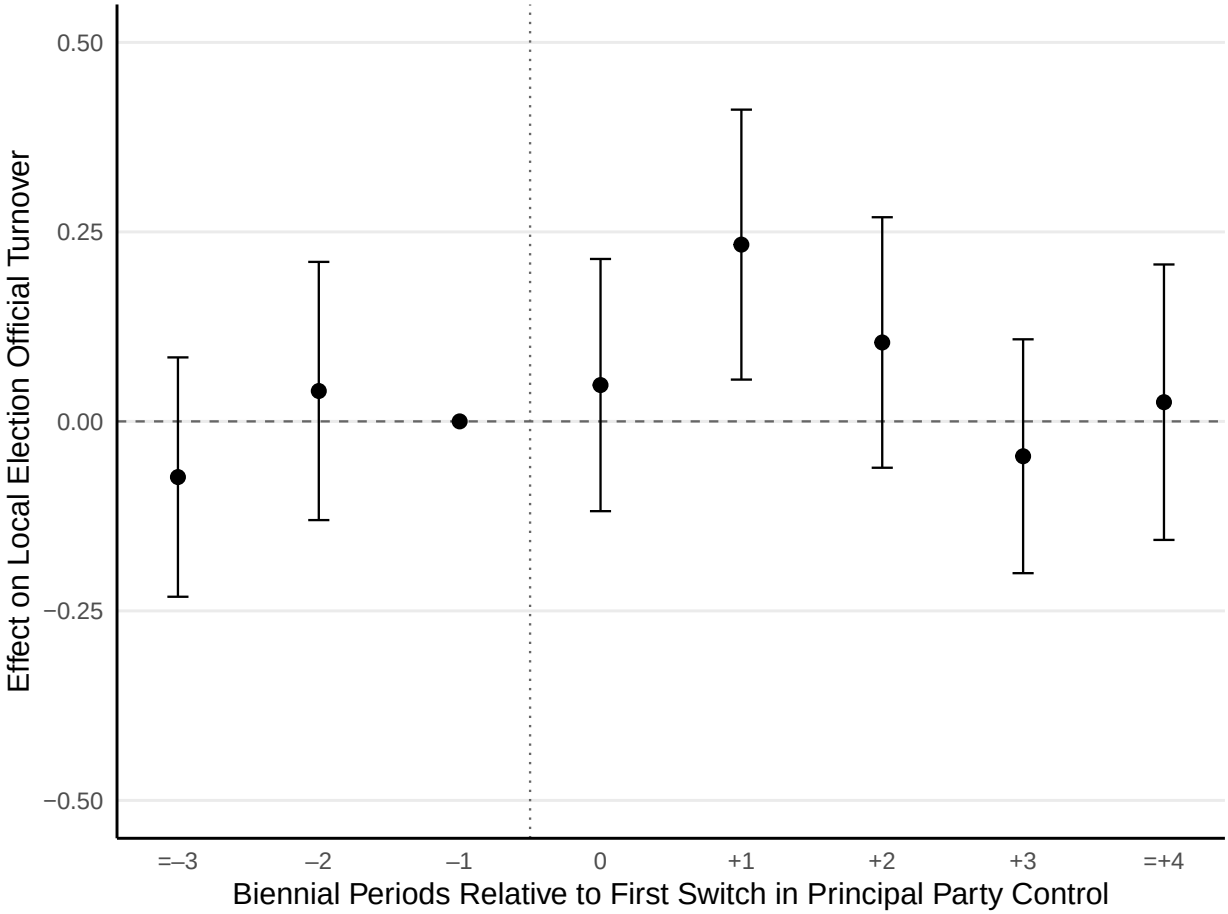


Table 3: **Effect of Democratic Principal by Turnover Status**

	Appointed Official Dem		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Dem Principal × Turnover	0.102	0.209	0.268
	(0.045)	(0.104)	(0.139)
Dem Principal × Stayer	0.085	0.187	0.256
	(0.027)	(0.099)	(0.144)
Counties	174	174	62
Elections (Avg)	12	12	12
Observations	2088	2088	744
Outcome Mean	0.39	0.39	0.36
County FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FEs	Yes	No	No
Year x State FEs	No	Yes	Yes
Comparisons	All	All	Clean

Robust standard errors clustered by county in parentheses. Sample limited to jurisdictions with full panel data of both principal party control and election official party affiliation from 2002 to 2024. Turnover indicates the appointed election official changed between biennial periods. Stayer indicates the same official remained as the chief election officer. Clean comparisons means the analysis is run on jurisdictions that do not switch principal party control more than once. Both coefficients come from the same regression with county and year (or year by state) fixed effects.

6 When Is The Effect of Partisanship in Bureaucratic Appointments Largest?

This section investigates when partisan influence in local bureaucratic appointment of election officials is greatest. I examine seven potential moderators: the strength of the local board's authority, the county's political competitiveness, the state's political competitiveness, the county's population, the county's importance in influencing state election results, the racial diversity of the county, and time period. I construct binary measures for each. Board authority comes from Ferrer and Thompson (2025). Boards are coded as strong when they have primary statutory authority to administer voting on Election Day and weak when they do not. Counties are coded as competitive if the two-party vote share in the 2024 presidential election was within 15 percentage points. States are coded as competitive if the two-party vote share was within 10 percentage points. Counties are considered large if they have more than 100,000 residents according to the 2020 Census. Counties are determinative if their population is at least half as large as the state two-party vote margin in the 2024 presidential election. Counties are considered racially diverse if they are comprised of less than 85 percent non-Hispanic whites. Finally, time period is split between 2002–2012 and 2014–2024.

Table 4 shows difference-in-difference regressions similar in form to column 5 of Table 2, with each moderator introduced as a separate interaction term. In the first column, the coefficient for Dem Principal means that in jurisdictions with relatively weak boards, a switch to Democratic control increases the probability that the Board appoints a Democratic election official by 27 percentage points. The interaction term can be interpreted as an additive effect: when the switch happens in counties with strong boards, the effect is about 17 percentage points ($27.4 - 10.8$). The difference is not statistically significant.

Surprisingly, there is more partisan influence in politically uncompetitive districts ($p < .05$) and in the first decade of the century ($p < .10$) rather than the past 10 years. The

Table 4: **Heterogeneous Effects of Democratic Principal on Democratic Election Officials**

	Board Authority (1)	District Compet. (2)	State Compet. (3)	County Pop. (4)	Determ. County (5)	Racial Diversity (6)	Time Period (7)
Dem Principal	0.274	0.205	0.267	0.199	0.216	0.196	0.267
	(0.122)	(0.096)	(0.147)	(0.100)	(0.102)	(0.100)	(0.109)
Dem P. × Strong	-0.108						
	(0.172)						
Dem P. × Juris Comp.		-0.135					
		(0.065)					
Dem P. × State Comp.			-0.091				
			(0.186)				
Dem P. × Large Pop.				-0.049			
				(0.056)			
Dem P. × Determinative					-0.089		
					(0.065)		
Dem P. × Diverse						-0.011	
						(0.056)	
Dem P. × Recent							-0.188
							(0.109)
Counties	174	174	174	163	163	174	174
Observations	2088	2088	2088	1956	1956	2088	2088
Outcome Mean	0.39	0.39	0.39	0.40	0.40	0.39	0.39
County FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year x State FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Robust standard errors clustered by county in parentheses. Sample limited to jurisdictions with full panel data of both principal party control and election official party affiliation from 2002 to 2024. Each column tests whether the effect of Democratic principal control varies by a different moderator. Strong means the appointing body has primary authority to administer elections, not the appointed official. Competitive district means the 2024 presidential vote share between the Democratic and Republican candidates was within 15 percentage points. Competitive state means 2024 state-level presidential two-party vote share was within 10 percentage points. Large Pop. means the county population is greater than 100,000 residents. Determinative means the county population is at least half as large as the state two-party vote margin in the 2024 presidential election. Diverse means the county is less than 85 percent non-Hispanic white, according to the 2020 Census. Recent means the period 2014-2024, compared with the period 2002-2012.

latter effect is counter to studies showing increasing polarization in state and local politics (Abramowitz and McCoy 2019; Hopkins 2018; Shor, McCarty et al. 2022). There also might be more partisan influence in uncompetitive states, in counties that are less politically im-

portant, and in smaller jurisdictions, though these effects are imprecisely estimated and not statistically significant. There are not clear differences in effect based on county population or racial diversity. Across nearly all subsets, there is a strong and statistically significant effect of Democratic control on Democratic appointments.

These results are robust to subsetting to counties with no more than one transition in party control (Table A.9) as well as to non-parametric matching analysis (Table A.10 and Figures A.6 and A.7). In general, these findings suggest that partisan influence in bureaucratic appointments is ubiquitous across counties regardless of their political or demographic makeup. It appears most common in politically uncompetitive areas—and therefore, when it is likely easiest to privilege partisan favoritism over quality and competence considerations.

7 Partisan Influence in the Appointment of Local Election Officials Does Not Impact The Quality of Election Administration

If the officials in charge of selecting election administrators are heavily influenced in their decision to retain or remove the currently serving appointee, this may lead partisan considerations to foreground decisions over administrative expertise and quality. This, in turn, could have detrimental effects on the quality of election administration. In other words, party loyalty is prioritized over high-quality management. I use five observable indicators of election administration quality in order to study the relationship between principal party changes and election quality: turnout, residual vote rate, provisional vote rate, and absentee ballot rejection rate.

Prior studies have found a link between quality election administration and voter turnout (Ferrer 2025; Pettigrew 2021). I collect county-level turnout from David Leip's Election

Atlas. Denominators for voting-age population come from Census estimates.[8] Residual vote—the percentage of voters who cast a ballot but leave the top race blank—is widely used as an indicator of election administration quality (Ferrer and Thompson 2025; Kropf et al. 2020; Stewart et al. 2020). It correlates with election administration errors such as poor ballot design, malfunctioning voting equipment, and inadequate poll worker training, leading voters to mistakenly cast a ballot without selecting a choice for the first contest. I compute residual vote as the number of ballots cast in a jurisdiction minus the number of votes cast in the race at the top of the ticket, the presidential election in years divisible by 4 and the gubernatorial election in other even years. I measure the provisional vote rate and the absentee ballot rejection rate from data collected by the U.S. Election Assistance Commission's EAVS dataset. Poor election administration could increase the number of people casting provisional ballots due to administrative errors with the registration file or inadequate training of poll workers, while ballot design flaws and insufficient communication with voters can lead to more absentee ballots that are rejected. Finally, I measure reporting errors as cases where the number of ballots cast exceed the total number of ballots recorded (in other words, the negative residual vote rate). This reflects a tabulation or reporting error made by election officials.

Table 5 shows the result of difference-in-difference estimators similar to those used in column 5 of Table 2. Each regression estimates the effect of a change in principal party control on a observable indicator of election quality. Across all five metrics, the estimated effect is statistically insignificant and substantively small. In Section A.7 of the online appendix, I conduct a series of robustness tests, including employing a lagged party switch and persistent party switch treatment variables, using the Callaway and Sant'Anna (2021) robust difference-in-differences estimator, and running non-parametric matching tests. The results are in line with those presented in Table 5: there appears to be little change in election quality when party control changes hands. This is consistent with the findings of

[8] I use estimates from the National Cancer Institute's Surveillance, Epidemiology and End Results Program available at `https://seer.cancer.gov/popdata/singleages.html`

previous literature on partisanship in election administration (Ferrer, Geyn, and Thompson 2024).

Table 5: **Effect of Principal Party Switch on Election Administration Outcomes**

	Turnout (1)	Residual Vote (2)	Provisional Ballot Rate (3)	Absentee Rejection (4)	Reporting Error (5)
Principal Party Switch	0.001	-0.000	0.000	-0.000	-0.004
	(0.003)	(0.001)	(0.000)	(0.005)	(0.010)
Counties	589	589	589	589	589
Elections (Avg)	10	8	8	9	8
Observations	5291	4215	4550	5373	4215
Outcome Mean	0.48	0.01	0.01	0.02	0.02
County FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year x State FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Robust standard errors clustered by county in parentheses. Sample limited to jurisdictions with full panel data of principal party control from 2002 to 2024 and that only vary between Democratic and Republican control. Principal Party Switch is an indicator for whether the partisan composition of the appointing authority changed between elections.

One related concern is that the change in election official itself could lead to decreased quality of election administration. However, recent findings suggest this is not the case. Ferrer and Thompson (2025) find turnover of local election officials makes little difference in the quality of election administration, including in voter turnout, self-reported problems with voting, confidence that the election was administered properly, the share of ballots cast provisionally, and the residual vote rate, with the only potential exception being a small increase in voter wait times. Considering the relationship between principal party change and turnover evidenced in this paper, Table 5 aligns with the conclusion that election official turnover generally has minimal effects on election administration.

8 Conclusion

If local bureaucracies were insulated from partisan politics, we would expect to see little relationship between the party of public officials and the party of local election bureaucrats. But that is exactly what is shown in this paper. Thousands of politicians with partisan affiliations are empowered throughout the country to select the bureaucrats tasked with administering democratic elections. In many cases, their decisions are influenced by the party that appointed the currently serving bureaucrats. There may not be a Democratic or Republican way to fill a pothole—but there certainly is a Democratic and Republican way of selecting the bureaucrat who gets the job done.

On the other hand, if local partisan politics resembled national partisan politics, the election official's party would not match their principal's party only 52% of the time. A changing of the guard would lead to near complete party realignment, rather than the partial realignment evidenced here. In short, local politics is still distinct from national politics.

Rather, this paper identifies a more nuanced reality: there is some degree of partisan selection in election administration, but it is not absolute, it is not growing in prevalence, it is strongest in politically uncompetitive areas, and it does not degrade the ability of bureaucrats to carry out essential government functions. The null effects on election quality coincide with a string of findings that underscore the resilience of America's election officials to deliver free and fair elections. Directly elected election officials act similarly regardless of their party affiliation (Ferrer, Geyn, and Thompson 2024), Democratic and Republican election officials tend to have less polarized election policy beliefs than their general public counterparts (Manion et al. 2021), partisan principals fail to gain an advantage for their party when they are in charge of appointments (Ferrer 2025), and turnover does not noticeably diminish the quality of election administration (Ferrer and Thompson 2025). Add to these the finding that switches in party control of election official appointments seem to have little impact on the quality of election administration, and it suggests that America's election infrastructure is highly resilient in the face of attempts at partisan interference.

Partisan influence can still have real human and institutional costs even if elections remain soundly administered. The greatest effects of partisan principal's decision-making lie in the personal cost to the public servants who are not reappointed due to their party affiliation and the public's confidence in election officials to act in a nonpartisan manner (Ferrer, Thompson, and Orey 2024; Norris and Grömping 2019; Stewart 2021). Election official turnover has grown 50% over the past two decades (Ferrer and Thompson 2025) and election official job satisfaction has dropped sharply in recent years.[9]. More than one in three election officials have reported threats, harassment, or abuse (Alexander and Gordon 2024),[10] and many work long hours for relatively meager pay (Adona et al. 2019). At the same time, public confidence in the integrity of elections in the U.S. is at record lows. According to Gallup, 43% of Americans stated being either not too confident or not at all confident that their vote would be accurately cast and counted in the 2024 presidential election, the highest percentage in the 20 years Gallup has asked the question.[11]. In short, both election officials and the institution of elections have come under increasing strain in recent years.

More broadly, these findings present an important counterpoint to evidence that partisan influence reduces bureaucratic performance (Cameron and de Figueiredo 2020; Krause, Lewis, and Douglas 2006; Lewis 2007, 2008; Spenkuch, Teso, and Xu 2023). For at least one essential government function, this is not the case.

[9] https://evic.reed.edu/evic-news/declining-job-satisfaction-among-local-election-administrators/

[10] See also https://www.brennancenter.org/our-work/research-reports/local-election-officials-survey-may-2024 and https://bridgingdivides.princeton.edu/analysis-threat-and-harassment-data-2024-election

[11] https://news.gallup.com/poll/651185/partisan-split-election-integrity-gets-even-wider.aspx

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Online Appendix

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Contents

A.1 Dataset of Local Election Officials and L2 Matching Procedure 34

A.2 Partisan Election Official Appointing Bodies 36

A.3 Description of Counties By Inclusion, Level of Variation, and Number of Principal Party Switches 38

A.4 Additional Election Official Party Tests 43

A.5 Tabular Output of Turnover Event Study 49

A.6 Additional Analysis of Heterogeneous Treatment Effects 50

A.7 Additional Election Administration Outcome Analysis 54

A.1 Dataset of Local Election Officials and L2 Matching Procedure

Panel data on chief local election officials is from Ferrer and Thompson (2025). This dataset captures the official who administered each even-year general election with primary responsibility for administering elections, especially overseeing voting on Election Day. In jurisdictions with boards, the dataset uses the single official with the most responsibility in running elections. The majority of this data was collected from election results and official directories housed in state and local government websites. Some was acquired via public information requests, through third-party organizations, and from direct communication with jurisdictions.

I estimate the party identification of appointed local election officials using historical voter file data from L2. I match election official names with voter file entries in four stages: first exact-match on full name, county, and year; then exact-match accounting for common nicknames, then match allowing missingness in middle or suffix fields or first initial match in middle name, and finally fuzzy name matching using SOUNDEX that requires the first three letters of both the last and first name to match exactly. In each case, I accept party information if only 1 exact match is made or, if multiple matches are made, if all agree on party identification. I mark as unmatched at any stage and all subsequent stages where multiple potential matches are identified that disagree on party. I have L2 voter file data from 2014 to 2020. I match 2020 election official names with voter file records from 2022 and 2024, and match pre-2014 election officials with 2014 data. This procedure results in 6,430 matches out of 9,885 county-year observations (a 65% success rate), of which 1,347 exact-match, 85 match with nicknames, 1,387 match with relaxed middle and name and suffix criteria, and 3,611 match with the fuzzy matching procedure. Only 40 total matches were non-unique with shared party ID, meaning the vast majority of cases resulted in a single successful match.

Voter file party affiliation data varies by state. Of the 18 states covered in analysis (see Table A.1), voters register with their party in two-thirds of them: Alaska, Arizona, Florida, Kansas, Maryland, North Carolina, Nebraska, Nevada, Oklahoma, Oregon, Pennsylvania, and West Virginia, as well as DC. Of the remaining six, party affiliation is applied using a combination of most recent partisan primary choice and modeling analytics in 5 states: Georgia, South Carolina, Tennessee, Texas, and Virginia. Voters self-report race in Georgia and Virginia voter files, providing a high-quality signal in the absence of primary participation. Only in Montana is party coded purely from in-house modeling, which uses demographic, commercial, and political contribution and election data. In short, party affiliation is voter-supplied in the vast majority of the dataset.

A.2 Partisan Election Official Appointing Bodies

I group election official appointing authorities into two categories: those that are selected at the state level, and those that are selected at the county level.

In the former case, politicians elected in statewide elections determine partisan control of county appointment bodies. The partisan affiliation of the Governor determines the majority party of local election boards in Maryland, North Carolina, Oklahoma, South Carolina, and Virginia. These boards in turn select each county's chief local election official. The party-affiliated lieutenant governor in Alaska selects the State Director of Elections, who in turn appoints Regional Election Supervisors. Appointments to Tennessee's State Elections Commission are made by the Tennessee General Assembly—a combination of their upper and lower state legislative chambers. The majority party of the Tennessee General Assembly selects more seats on the State Elections Commission. The State Elections Commission then makes appointments to the county election commissions, which finally appoint an administrator of elections in each county.

In the later case, the partisanship of principals is determined by county-level officials. County legislative bodies in Arizona, Montana, Nevada, Oregon, Pennsylvania, and West Virginia hold appointing authority for chief local election officials that are appointed in these states. In Texas, elections administrators are appointed by the county election commission, which is composed of the county judge, county clerk, county tax assessor, and county chair of each major party.

In some states, election official appointment methods vary between jurisdictions. In Nebraska, the Governor appoints county election commissioners in counties with over 100,000 residents, whereas the county legislative board makes these appointments for smaller jurisdictions that use an appointed election commissioner. Georgia county appointing bodies take numerous different forms and counties frequently change the composition of their boards. The most common arrangement empowers the county legislative body to make appointments to the board of elections that in turn appoints the local election official, but it is also com-

mon to allow each major party to make an appointment to the board and to empower the nonpartisan superior court judge to select a member.

County appointing boards vary in size but are almost always an odd number. They are usually either 3 or 5 people, but are as large as 11 and as small as a single individual.

Table A.1 provides a summary of these appointing authorities. 'County-level variation' indicates whether the partisanship of the appointing authority is determined at the county level rather than the state level. 'Uniform' indicates whether the appointing structures are the same across included jurisdictions.

Table A.1: **Local Election Officials Included**

State	Election Official	Geography	Jurisdictions	County-level variation	Uniform	1st degree offices	1st degree size	1st degree partisan	2nd degree office	2nd degree size	2nd degree partisan
AK	Regional Election Supervisor	Region	5	0	1	State Director of Elections	1	No	Lt. Governor	1	Yes
AZ	County Election Administrator	County	13	1	1	Board of Supervisors	3 or 5	Yes			
DC	Executive Director	County	1	0	1	Board of Elections	3	Yes	Mayor	1	Yes
FL	Supervisor of Elections	County	1	1	1	County Mayor	1	Yes			
GA	Elections Director	County	115	1	0	Board of Elections					
KS	Election Commission	County	4	0	1	Secretary of State	1	Yes			
MD	County elections administrator	County	24	0	1	County Board of Elections	5	Yes	Governor	1	Yes
MT	Election Administrator	County	4	1	1	Board of County Commissioners	3	Yes			
NC	County Elections Director	County	100	0	1	County Board of Elections	5	Yes	Governor	1	Yes
NE	Election Commissioner	County	4	1	1	County Board	3, 5, or 7	Yes			
NE	Election Commissioner	County	3	0	1	Governor	1	Yes			
NV	Registrar of Voters	County	2	1	1	County Commission	5	Yes			
OK	Election Board Secretary	County	77	0	1	State Board of Elections	3	Yes	Governor	1	Yes
OR	Elections Manager / Director	County	1	1	1	Board of County Commissioners	3	Yes			
PA	Election Director / Chief Registrar	County	67	1	0	County Election Board	3	Yes	Board of County Commissioners	3	Yes
SC	County Director of Voter Registration and Elections	County	46	0	1	County Board of Elections	5	Yes	Governor	1	Yes
TN	Administrator of Elections	County	95	0	1	County Election Commission	5	Yes	State Elections Commission	7	Yes
TX	Elections Administrator	County	135	1	1	County Election Commission	5	Yes			
VA	General Registrar	County	133	0	1	Local Electoral Board	3	Yes	Governor		
WV	Elections Coordinator	County	1	1	1	County Commission	3	Yes			

This table lists information about the jurisdictions from states included in the data. Number of jurisdictions are total number of jurisdictions in that state that appoint election officials with partisan principals at least some point between 2004 and 2022. In states where multiple officials are coded, a '/' separates each distinct official and they are listed in order by frequency. County-level variation indicates whether jurisdiction's principal appointing authority varies at the county level rather than the state level. Nebraska is listed twice because some counties vary at the county level and some vary at the state level. Uniform indicates whether included jurisdictions within the state vary in terms of their appointment structures. Where there is variation, the most common appointment structure is provided. '1st degree' is the direct appointing authority of the local election official. '2nd degree' is the appointing authority of the 1st degree authority, where the direct appointing authority is not directly elected.

A.3 Description of Counties By Inclusion, Level of Variation, and Number of Principal Party Switches

Table A.2 shows descriptive characteristics of counties in and not in the analysis sample, including population, partisanship, income, racial demographics, and region. In-sample counties are those that have continuously used partisan principals to appoint their local election officials between 2002 and 2024.[12] For time-varying descriptive statistics, 2020 data sources are used (Census or Leip's Election Atlas). In-sample counties tend to be more populous and more racially diverse than out-of-sample counties. They are also mostly located in the South. In-sample counties are slightly more Democratic and slightly wealthier, but have similar levels of election official turnover.

Table A.3 compares the characteristics of county-level and state-level variation in-sample counties. This is important because the statistical tests used to estimate the effect of principal party switches on election official turnover mostly uses the county-level variation sample. These county-level variation jurisdictions are significantly more populous and have higher average election official turnover than state-level variation jurisdictions. They also have higher Hispanic populations on average, though are similar in terms of partisanship and median income. Whereas virtually all counties that use state-level politicians to determine the partisanship of county boards are in the South, county-level variation counties are more geographically diverse.

Table A.4 shows descriptive characteristics of in-sample counties by the number of changes in principal party control between 2002 and 2024. Only counties with full panel histories of major party majority control are included. The never switched counties in column 1 are control jurisdictions and the switched once counties in column 2 are treated jurisdictions in most difference-in-differences and generalized synthetic control analysis. The non-parametric

[12]The small discrepancy in in-sample county n-size is due to the dropping of Alaska's election regions.

matching design allows the inclusion of counties with multiple switches in principal partisanship.

The groups are similar in terms of partisanship. However, they differ on other characteristics, especially population, racial demographics and geographic location. It is also important to note that there is a much larger pool of jurisdictions with multiple changes in principal party control than jurisdictions with either no or exactly 1 switch. These descriptives underline the importance of the non-parametric matching design in allowing the inclusion of more counties.

Table A.2: **Description of Counties In and Not In Sample**

	In Sample (1)	Not In Sample (2)
Population (Thousdands)	138.15	93.43
	(287.36)	(383.07)
Dem Pres Vote Share	0.39	0.36
	(0.12)	(0.14)
Election Official Turnover	0.19	0.18
	(0.11)	(0.11)
Median Income	57,882	54,763
	(14,609)	(17,710)
Share Non-Hispanic White	0.70	0.77
	(0.19)	(0.20)
Share Black	0.15	0.08
	(0.16)	(0.14)
Share Hispanic	0.08	0.10
	(0.11)	(0.15)
Northeast	0.10	0.03
Midwest	0.01	0.42
South	0.86	0.37
West	0.03	0.17
Num Counties	656	2299

Standard deviations are reported in parentheses below group means. Counties for the 8 states with municipal-level election administration (CT, MA, ME, MI, NH, RI, VT, WI) are not included in the out-of-sample descriptive characteristics. Alaska election regions are not included in the in-smaple descriptive characteristics.

Table A.3: **Description of County-Level and State-Level Variation Counties**

	County-Level Variation (1)	State-Level Variation (2)
Population (Thousdands)	255.78	91.74
	(453.18)	(164.42)
Dem Pres Vote Share	0.40	0.39
	(0.13)	(0.12)
Election Official Turnover	0.23	0.17
	(0.12)	(0.10)
Median Income	57,882	54,763
	(14,609)	(17,710)
Share Non-Hispanic White	0.68	0.71
	(0.24)	(0.18)
Share Black	0.13	0.16
	(0.16)	(0.16)
Share Hispanic	0.14	0.06
	(0.19)	(0.06)
Northeast	0.39	0.00
Midwest	0.01	0.01
South	0.51	0.98
West	0.09	0.01
Num Counties	174	482

Standard deviations are reported in parentheses below group means.

Table A.4: **Description of Counties by Number of Principal Party Switches**

	Never Switched (1)	Switched Once (2)	Switched Multiple (3)
Population (Thousdands)	307.83	141.03	102.44
	(466.41)	(297.15)	(223.09)
Dem Pres Vote Share	0.40	0.39	0.39
	(0.14)	(0.11)	(0.12)
Election Official Turnover	0.23	0.19	0.17
	(0.13)	(0.11)	(0.10)
Median Income	59,803	50,847	57,324
	(15,272)	(13,229)	(18,667)
Share Non-Hispanic White	0.66	0.73	0.70
	(0.26)	(0.20)	(0.17)
Share Black	0.09	0.16	0.15
	(0.14)	(0.17)	(0.16)
Share Hispanic	0.18	0.07	0.07
	(0.23)	(0.10)	(0.07)
Northeast	0.35	0.09	0.07
Midwest	0.06	0.00	0.01
South	0.43	0.89	0.92
West	0.16	0.02	0.00
Num Counties	68	194	367

Standard deviations are reported in parentheses below group means.

A.4 Additional Election Official Party Tests

Table A.5 replicates the results of the main analysis, substituting Republican election officials instead of Democratic election officials as the dependent variable.

Table A.5: **Effect of Switch in Party of Appointing Authority On Party of Appointed Election Official**

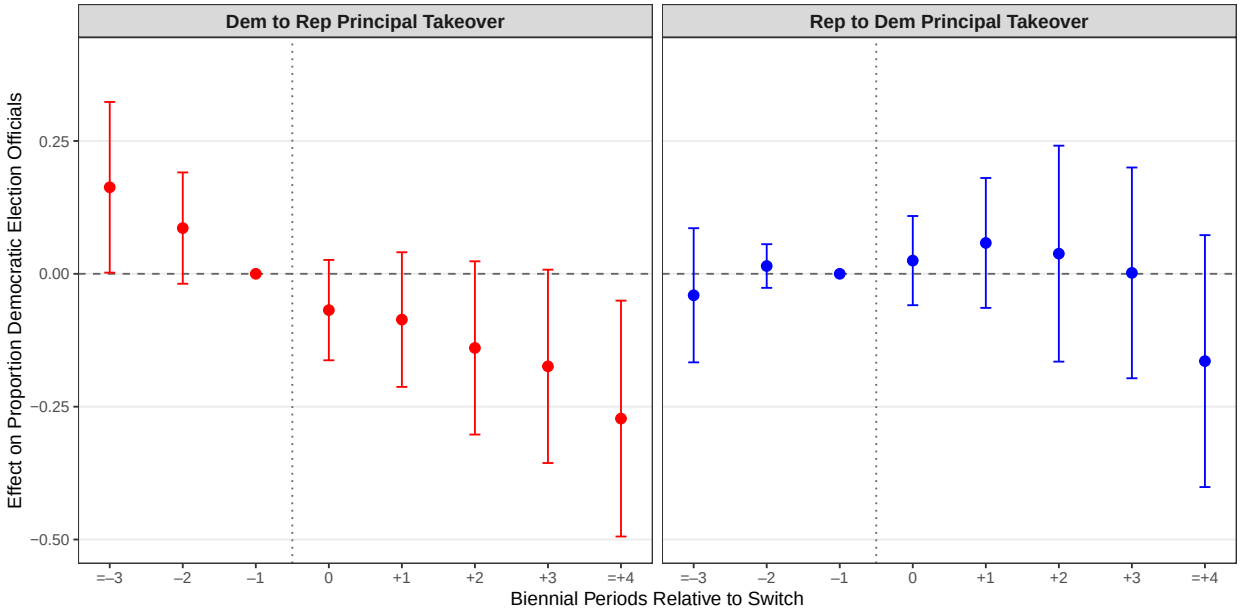
	Appointed Election Official Republican					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Dem Principal Control	-0.149	-0.268	-0.209	-0.070	-0.132	-0.210
	(0.017)	(0.023)	(0.041)	(0.026)	(0.098)	(0.152)
Counties	841	761	174	174	174	62
Elections (Avg)	13	13	12	12	12	12
Observations	9574	6192	2088	2088	2088	744
Outcome Mean	0.32	0.50	0.46	0.46	0.46	0.54
County FEs	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	No	No
Year x State FEs	No	No	No	No	Yes	Yes
Sample	Full	Full	Panel	Panel	Panel	Panel
Missing as 0	Yes	No	No	No	No	No
Comparisons	All	All	All	All	All	Clean

Robust standard errors clustered by county in parentheses. Panel sample limited to jurisdictions with full panel data of both principal party control and election official party affiliation, from 2002 to 2024. Missing as 0 means that unknown appointed official's parties are imputed as 0 (not Republican) rather than left as NA. Clean comparisons means the analysis is run on jurisdictions that do not switch principal party control more than once.

Figure A.1 shows the results of two event-study regressions: one testing the effect of a transition from Democratic to Republican principal party control (left panel) and the other testing the effect of a transition from Republican to Democratic principal party control (right panel). In both cases, the effect is the propensity for the appointed election official to be affiliated with the Democratic party.

Figure A.2 and Table A.6 show the result of Callaway and Sant'Anna (2021) dynamic doubly robust difference-in-difference estimations. Note that these estimations do not include state fixed effects, as the estimator is unable to find suitable pre-treatment periods to test

Figure A.1: **Event Study of Principal Party Changes on Election Official Party**. This shows two event-study plots: the transition from Democratic to Republican principal party control (left panel) and the transition from Republican to Democratic principal party control (right panel). In both cases, the effect is the propensity for the appointed election official to be Democratic. The first party transition is used. Results are relative to the biennial period prior to treatment (-1). Results from time periods greater than 2 periods prior to treatment or greater than 3 periods after treatment are pooled together. 95% confidence intervals are shown.



when state is included as a covariate. This means the results are similar to column 3 of Table 2 and are susceptible to bias causes by differential trending between states.

Figure A.3 shows the result of an exact matching procedure identical to the left panel of Figure 2. Rather than the estimated effect, the y-axis shows the average proportion of jurisdictions under Republican control (black) and Democratic control (red) with a Democratic-affiliated appointed election official, after either the jurisdiction switches to Democratic control or remains under Democratic control (relative to a matched pair that remains under Republican control or switches to Republican control, respectively).

Figure A.4 shows the results of a non-parametric matching analysis identical to that used to produce the left panel of Figure 2. Rather than fixing the number of pre-treatment matched biennial periods at 3, this shows the results of varying the number of biennial

Figure A.2: **Effect of Principal Party Change on Democratic Election Official - Callaway and Sant'Anna (2021)**. This shows two event-study plots using the dynamic doubly robust Callaway and Sant'Anna (2021) difference-in-differences estimator: the transition from Democratic to Republican principal party control (left panel) and the transition from Republican to Democratic principal party control (right panel). In both cases, the effect is the propensity for the appointed election official to be Democratic. The first party transition in the panel is used as the treatment. Results are relative to the biennial period prior to treatment (-1). 95% bootstrapped confidence intervals are shown.

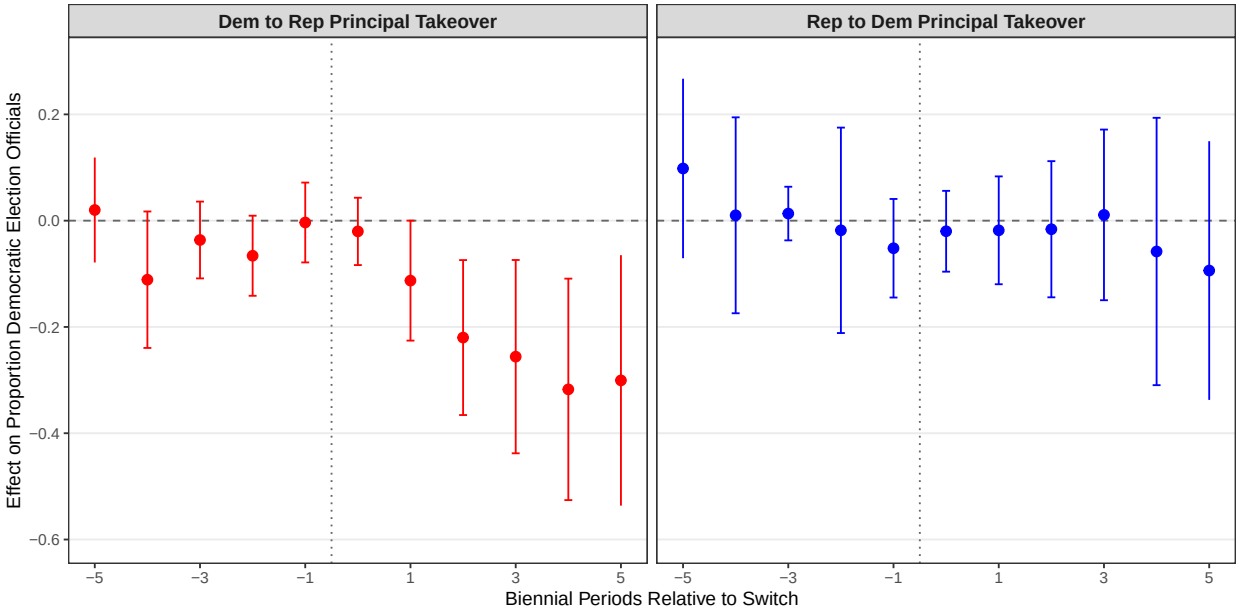
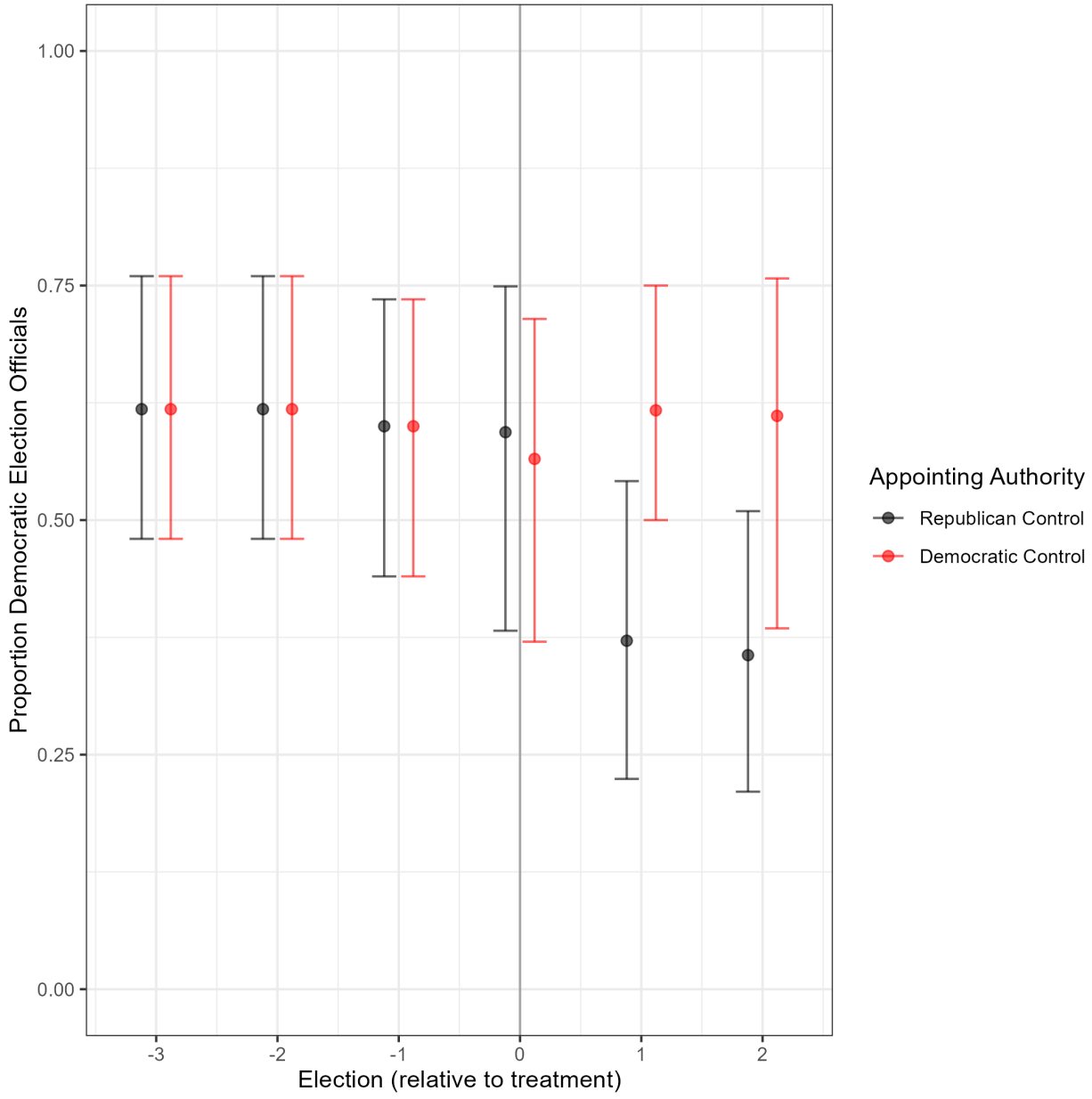


Table A.6: **Callaway-Sant'Anna Dynamic Event Study: Effect of Party Switch on Democratic Election Officials**

	R→D	D→R
	(1)	(2)
Overall ATT	-0.159	-0.266
	(0.072)	(0.113)
Counties	117	117
Observations	6192	6192

Robust standard errors clustered by county in parentheses. Column (1) shows effects when Republicans cede control to Democrats. Column (2) shows effects when Democrats cede control to Republicans. Overall ATT aggregates dynamic treatment effects across all post-treatment periods using a doubly robust Callaway and Sant'Anna estimator and never-treated counties as the control. Bootstrapped standard errors are constructed using 1000 iterations.

Figure A.3: **Exact-Match Event Study Election Official Democratic Means**. This shows the election official party means of an exact matching procedure that matches the prior three biennial periods of principal and election official partisanship, making comparisons between matching same-state counties that become or stay under Democratic control with those that do not. Error bars reflect 95% bootstrapped confidence intervals run with 1,000 simulations.



periods matched from only 1 period up to 6 pre-treatment periods. Fewer pre-treatment periods matched will result in less causally credible results, but more pre-treatment periods

matched will result in less precise estimates due to the more stringent data requirements for inclusion.

Figure A.4: **Exact-Match Dynamic ATT of Democratic Principal on Democratic Election Official by Years Matched**. This shows the dynamic ATT estimates produced by an exact matching procedure that matches the prior X biennial periods of principal and election official partisanship, making comparisons between matching same-state counties that become or stay under Democratic control in the following biennial period with those that do not. Error bars reflect 95% bootstrapped confidence intervals run with 1,000 simulations. The estimated dynamic effect is a weighted average of the ATT calculated for the first three post-treatment biennial periods.

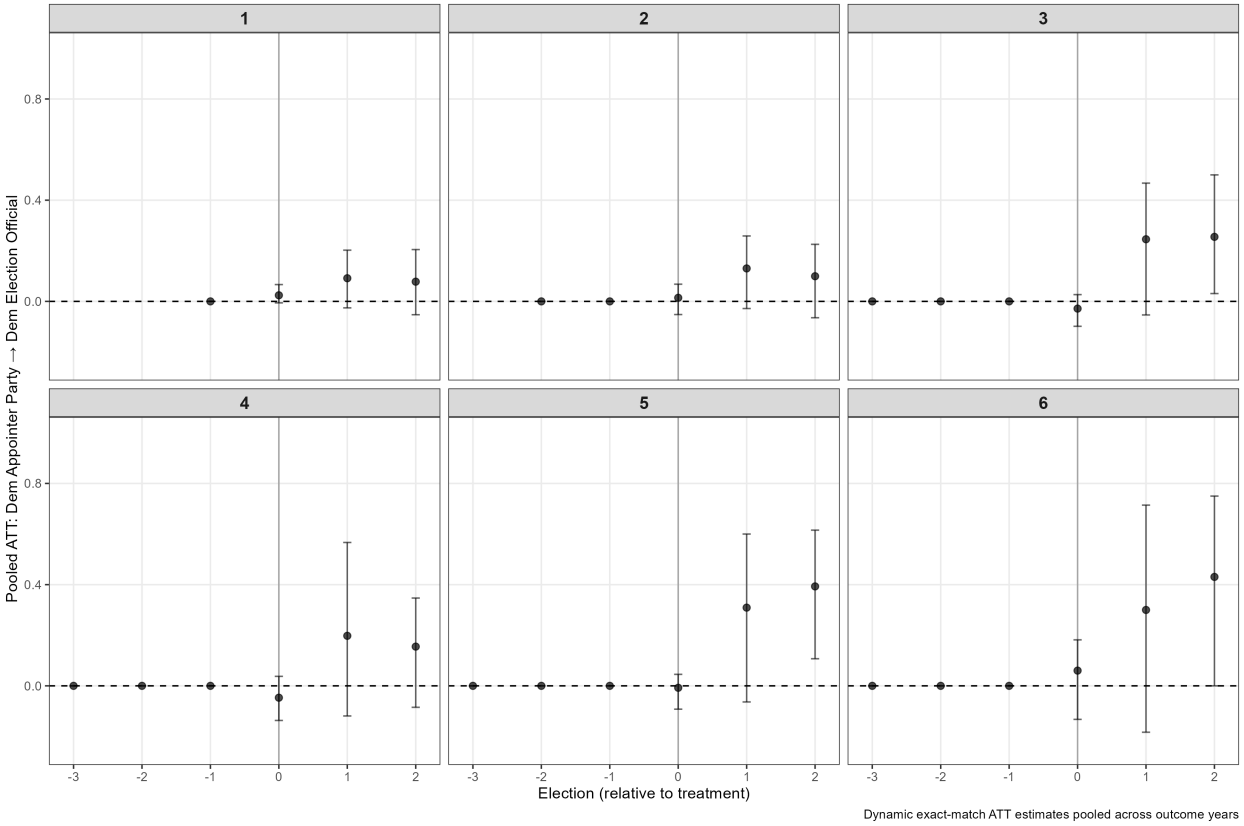


Figure A.5 and Table A.7 show the output of nonparametric matching estimations described in the main text, with the estimated dynamic effects of Democratic principal control on Democratic election official affiliation derived from pooling the ATTs of three post-treatment periods. As with Figure A.4, the number of pre-treatment periods used for matching is varied between 1 and 6, and the results for each shown.

Figure A.5: **Exact-Match Dynamic Pooled ATT of Democratic Principal on Democratic Election Official by Years Matched**. This shows the dynamic pooled ATT estimates produced by an exact matching procedure that matches the prior X biennial periods of principal and election official partisanship, making comparisons between matching same-state counties that become or stay under Democratic control in the following biennial period with those that do not. Error bars reflect 95% bootstrapped confidence intervals run with 1,000 simulations.

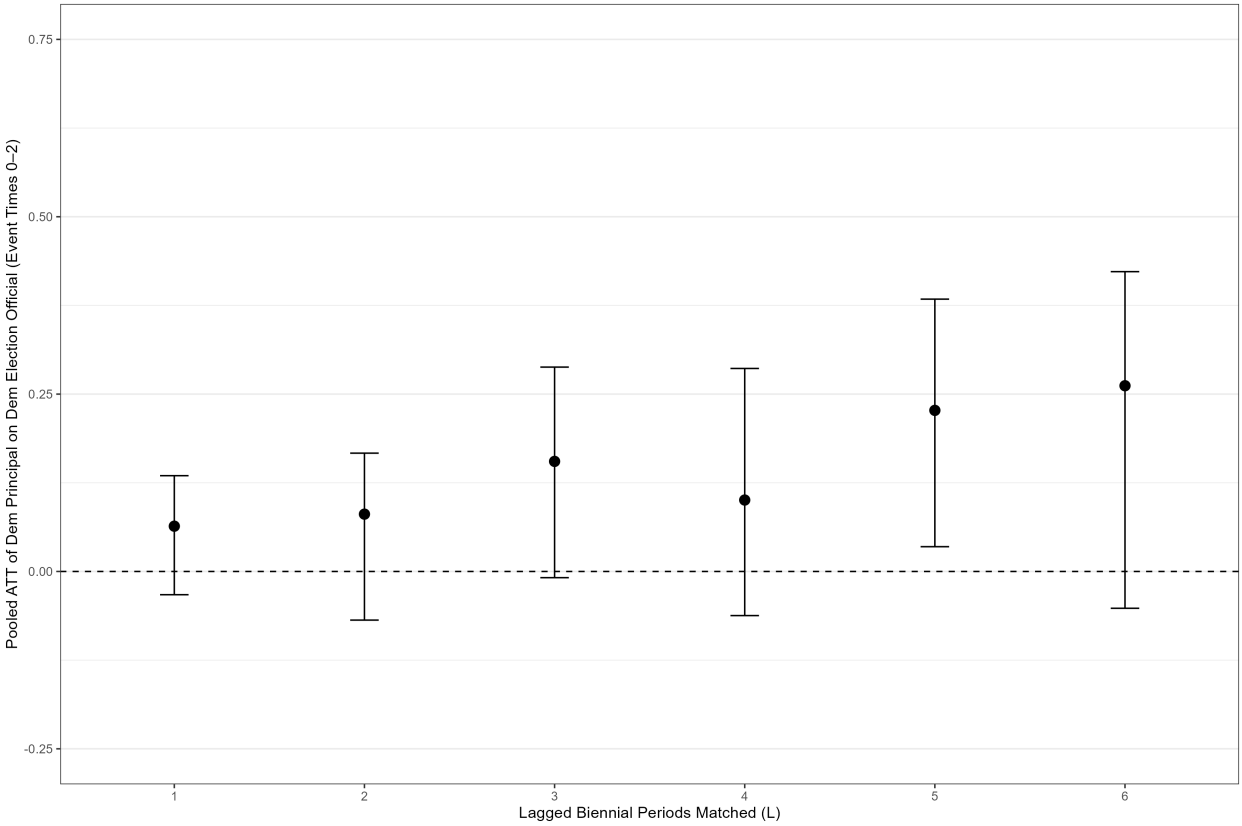


Table A.7: Dynamic ATT Estimates of Democratic Appointer on Democratic Election Official

	Dynamic ATT (Event-Time 0–2)			
Lag (L)	ATT	CI Low	CI High	N
1	0.064	-0.018	0.137	351
2	0.081	-0.010	0.170	242
3	0.155	-0.013	0.288	135
4	0.101	-0.062	0.286	90
5	0.227	0.035	0.384	57
6	0.262	-0.052	0.423	32

A.5 Tabular Output of Turnover Event Study

Table A.8 shows tabular output for the event study analysis displayed in Figure 3 in the main text.

Table A.8: **Event-Study: Effect of Party Switch on Election Official Turnover**

	(1)
Event time = $\leq$ -3	-0.073
	(0.080)
Event time = -2	0.040
	(0.086)
Event time = 0	0.048
	(0.084)
Event time = +1	0.233
	(0.090)
Event time = +2	0.104
	(0.084)
Event time = +3	-0.046
	(0.078)
Event time = $\geq$ +4	0.025
	(0.092)
Counties	194
Elections	8
Observations	2328
Outcome Mean	0.19
County FEs	Yes
Year $\times$ State FEs	Yes

Robust standard errors clustered by county in parentheses. Estimates reflect deviations from the pre-treatment year ($t = -1$). Election official turnover is measured as a proportion out of 1.

A.6 Additional Analysis of Heterogeneous Treatment Effects

Table A.9 shows the results of regressions testing for heterogeneity in the effect of Democratic principal control on the appointment of Democratic election officials. The specification is identical to Table 4 in the main analysis, except that results are subset to counties with no more than one transition in party control to ensure cleaner comparisons. The results are in line with those in the main analysis.

Table A.10 shows the tabular output of non-parametric matching estimators that match on three periods of pre-treatment principal and appointee partisanship. The matching estimator calculates the difference in treatment effect between the two levels of each potential moderator. Due to the temporal nature of the matching exercise, I am unable to calculate effects for different time periods. Figure A.6 shows the 12 calculated ATTs for the six remaining moderators, two for each moderator. Figure A.7 visualizes the difference in ATT calculated using this procedure from the estimates produced in Table A.10. The results are generally in line with those of the main analysis: partisan selection is strongest in politically uncompetitive and small jurisdictions.

Table A.9: **Heterogeneous Effects: Clean Comparisons Sample**

	Board Authority (1)	District Compet. (2)	State Compet. (3)	County Pop. (4)	Determ. County (5)	Racial Diversity (6)	Time Period (7)
Dem Principal	0.274	0.321	0.267	0.307	0.347	0.250	0.321
	(0.126)	(0.123)	(0.152)	(0.157)	(0.179)	(0.164)	(0.154)
Dem P. × Strong	-0.027						
	(0.251)						
Dem P. × Juris Comp.		-0.878					
		(0.257)					
Dem P. × State Comp.			-0.013				
			(0.241)				
Dem P. × Large Pop.				-0.186			
				(0.115)			
Dem P. × Determinative					-0.291		
					(0.255)		
Dem P. × Diverse						0.010	
						(0.163)	
Dem P. × Recent							-0.138
							(0.109)
Counties	62	62	62	62	62	62	62
Observations	744	744	744	744	744	744	744
Outcome Mean	0.36	0.36	0.36	0.36	0.36	0.36	0.36
County FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year x State FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Sample	Clean	Clean	Clean	Clean	Clean	Clean	Clean

Robust standard errors clustered by county in parentheses. Sample limited to jurisdictions with full panel data of both principal party control and election official party affiliation from 2002 to 2024, and that switch principal party control at most once (clean comparisons). Each column tests whether the effect of Democratic principal control varies by a different moderator. Strong means the appointing body has primary authority to administer elections, not the appointed official. Competitive district means the 2024 presidential vote share between the Democratic and Republican candidates was within 15 percentage points. Competitive state means 2024 state-level presidential two-party vote share was within 10 percentage points. Large Pop. means the county population is greater than 100,000 residents. Determinative means the county population is at least half as large as the state two-party vote margin in the 2024 presidential election. Diverse means the county is less than 85 percent non-Hispanic white, according to the 2020 Census. Recent means the period 2014-2024, compared with the period 2002-2012.

Table A.10: Heterogeneous Treatment Effects via Exact Matching (Average Dynamic ATT)

Moderator	Group A	ATT	Group B	ATT	Diff	95\% CI
Board Authority	Strong	0.164	Weak	0.062	0.102	[-0.098, 0.291]
District Competitiveness	Competitive	-0.300	Uncompetitive	0.186	-0.486	[-0.650, -0.246]
State Competitiveness	Competitive	0.164	Uncompetitive	0.062	0.102	[-0.140, 0.296]
County Population	Large	-0.190	Small	0.322	-0.512	[-0.658, -0.153]
Determinative County	Determinative	-0.060	Not	0.326	-0.385	[-0.488, -0.172]
Racial Diversity	Diverse	0.317	Homogeneous	-0.048	0.364	[0.079, 0.745]

Figure A.6: **Heterogeneous Treatment Effects of Democratic Principal Control on Democratic Election Official - Matching Estimation**. This shows the ATT estimates produced by an exact matching procedure that matches within-state on the prior three biennial periods of principal partisanship and election official partisanship patterns. The ATT estimated is the effect based on six different binary groupings: board authority, district competitiveness, state competitiveness, district population, county importance in state election outcome, and racial diversity. Error bars reflect 95% bootstrapped confidence intervals.

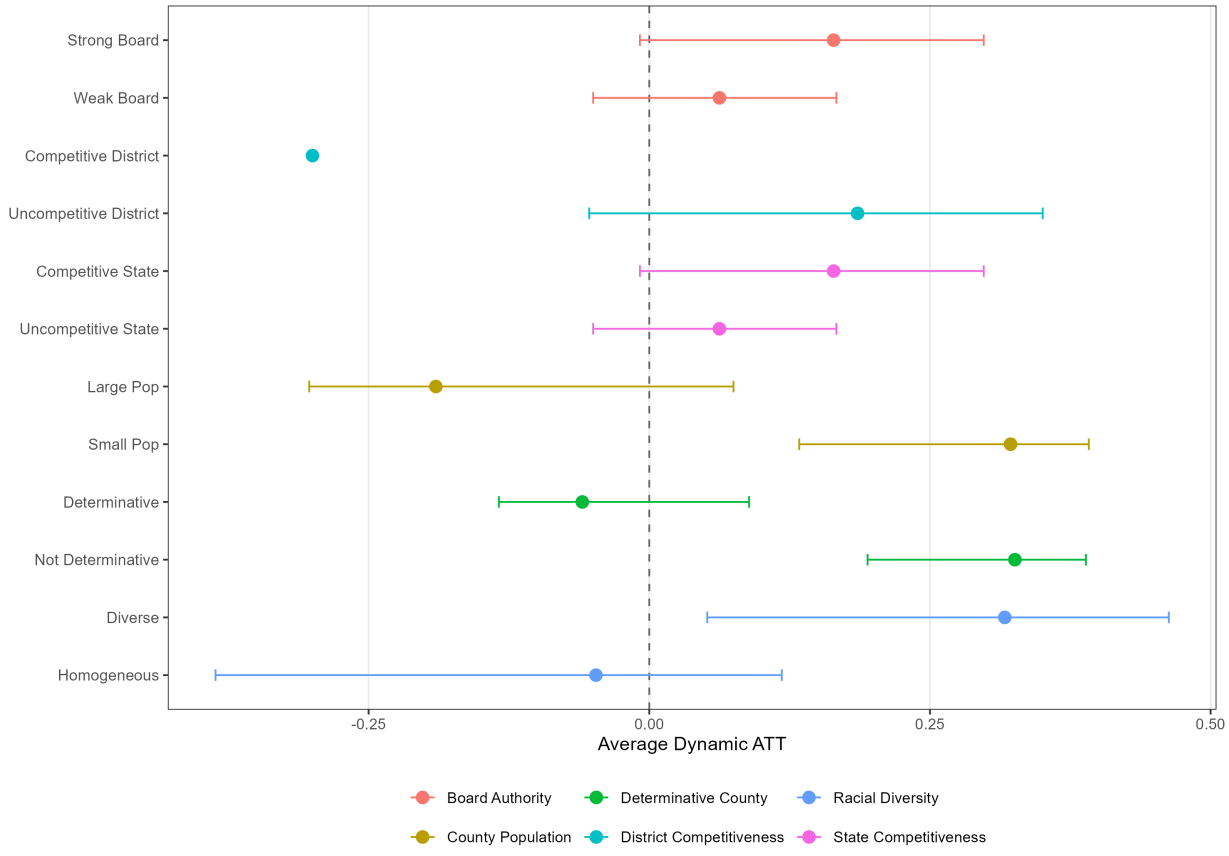
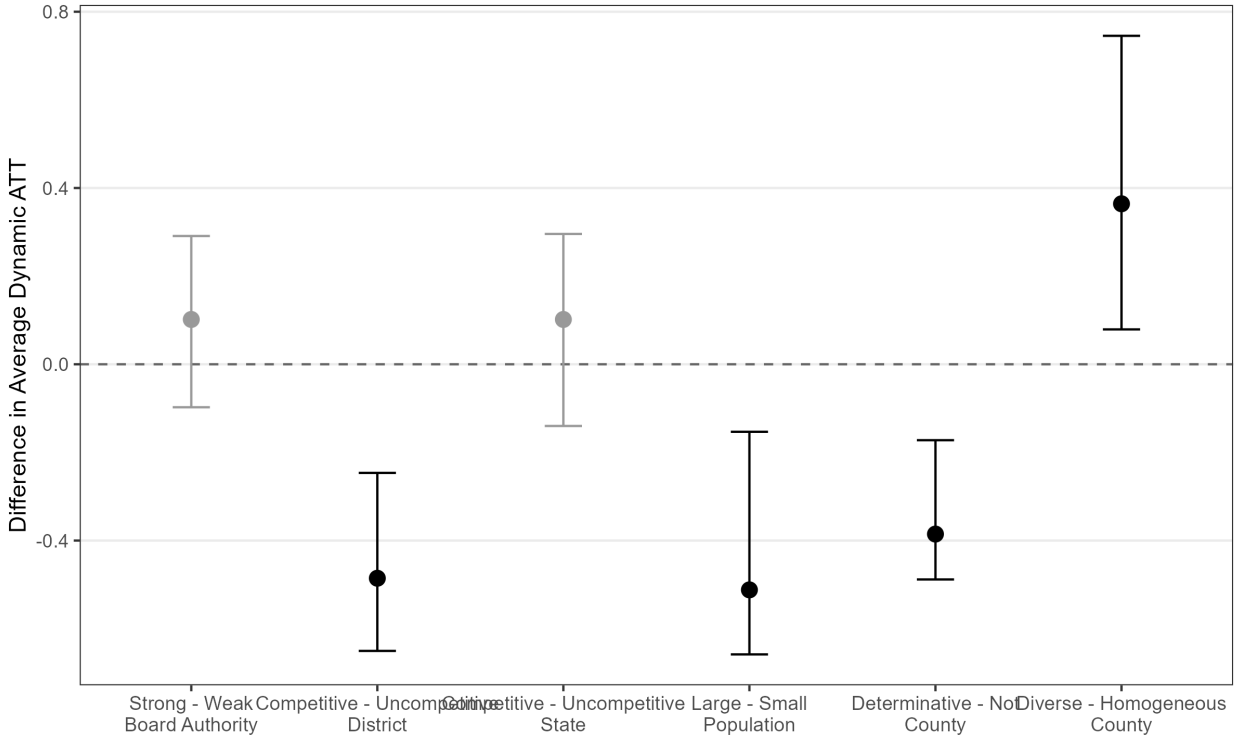


Figure A.7: **Heterogeneous Treatment Effect of Democratic Principal Control on Democratic Election Official - Matching Estimation Differences**. This shows the ATT estimates produced by an exact matching procedure that matches within-state on the prior three biennial periods of principal partisanship and election official partisanship patterns. The ATT estimated is the difference in effect based on six different binary groupings: board authority, district competitiveness, state competitiveness, district population, county importance in state election outcome, and racial diversity. Error bars reflect 95% bootstrapped confidence intervals.



A.7 Additional Election Administration Outcome Analysis

Table A.11 shows the results of difference-in-differences regressions identical to Table 5, with party switch lagged. This is to detect potential delayed effects of party change on election administration, since the main analysis showed that partisan influence appears strongest in the biennial period following the transition in power. Table A.12 subsets to counties that either never switch party control or only switch once and tests the persistent effects of a party switch on election administration. Table A.13 and Figure A.8 show the result of Callaway and Sant'Anna (2021) dynamic estimators (Reporting errors are omitted due to a failure of the estimator to identifiable suitable pre-treatment periods to test.) The results are unchanged in each case: there does not appear to be any discernible effect of a principal party switch on the quality of election administration.

Table A.11: **Lagged Effect of Principal Party Switch on Election Administration Outcomes**

	Turnout	Residual Vote	Provisional Ballot Rate	Absentee Rejection	Reporting Error
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Party Switch (t-1)	0.002	-0.000	0.001	-0.004	0.003
	(0.003)	(0.001)	(0.000)	(0.003)	(0.003)
Counties	589	586	589	589	586
Elections (Avg)	9	8	8	9	8
Observations	4899	3992	4550	5367	3992
Outcome Mean	0.49	0.01	0.01	0.02	0.01
County FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year x State FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Robust standard errors clustered by county in parentheses. Sample limited to jurisdictions with full panel data of principal party control from 2002 to 2024 and that only vary between Democratic and Republican control. Party Switch (t-1) is an indicator for whether the partisan composition of the appointing authority changed in the previous biennial period, capturing the one-period lagged effect of the party change.

Table A.12: **Effect of Persistent Principal Party Switch on Election Administration Outcomes**

	Turnout (1)	Residual Vote (2)	Provisional Ballot Rate (3)	Absentee Rejection (4)	Reporting Error (5)
Persistent Party Switch	-0.001	0.000	-0.000	0.004	-0.004
	(0.005)	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.007)	(0.004)
Counties	262	262	262	262	262
Elections (Avg)	6	5	5	6	5
Observations	2864	2247	1993	2316	2247
Outcome Mean	0.44	0.01	0.00	0.02	0.02
County FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year x State FEs	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Sample	Clean	Clean	Clean	Clean	Clean

Robust standard errors clustered by county in parentheses. Sample limited to jurisdictions with full panel data of principal party control from 2002 to 2024, that only vary between Democratic and Republican control, and that switch principal party control at most once. Persistent Party Switch is an indicator that equals 1 for all periods after a principal party switch occurs, capturing the sustained effect of the party change rather than just the instantaneous effect.

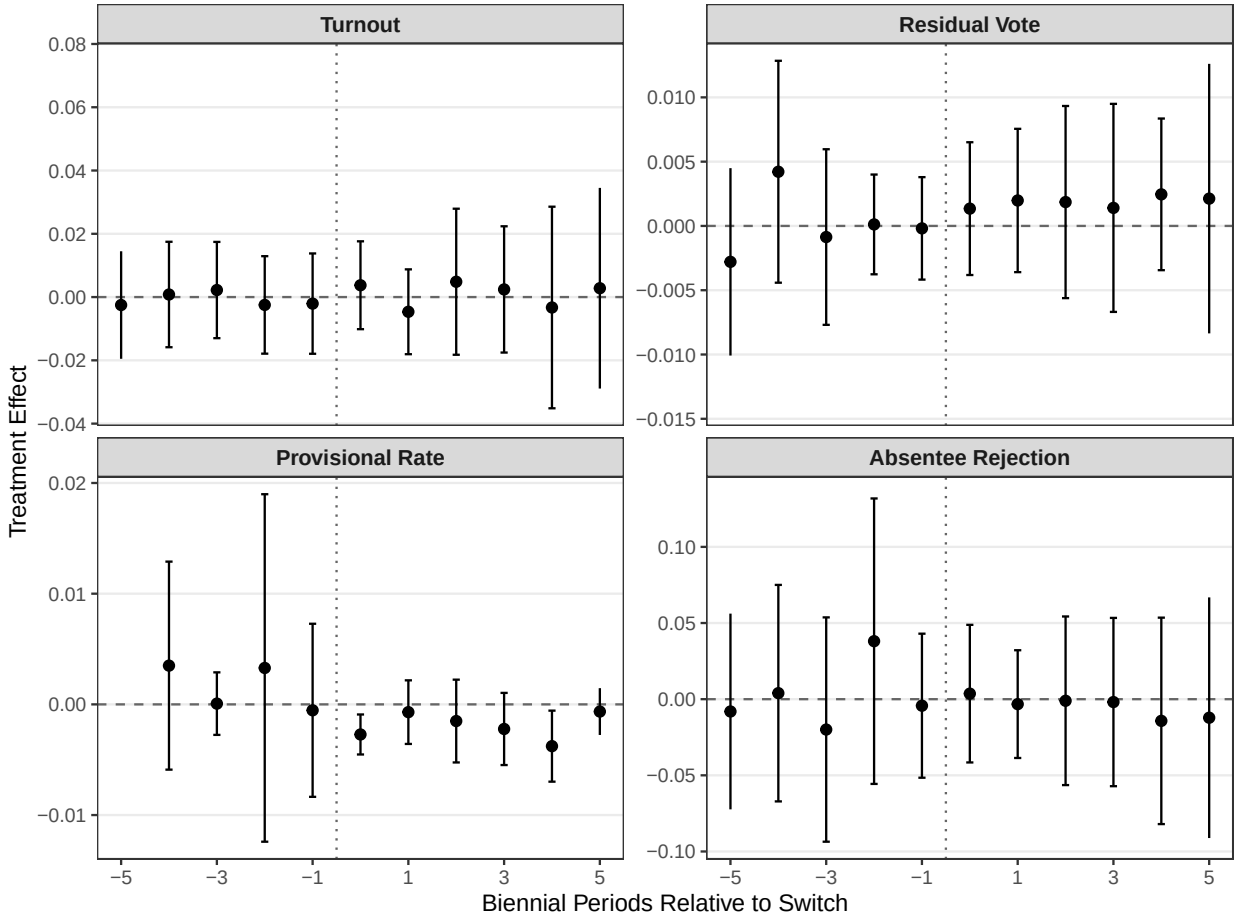
Table A.13: **Callaway-Sant'Anna Event Study: Effect of Principal Party Switch on Election Administration Outcomes**

	Turnout (1)	Residual Vote (2)	Provisional Ballot Rate (3)	Absentee Rejection (4)
Overall ATT	0.001	0.001	-0.002	0.003
	(0.007)	(0.002)	(0.001)	(0.025)
Counties	380	112	183	139
Observations	7542	7542	7542	7542

Robust standard errors clustered by county in parentheses. Overall ATT aggregates dynamic treatment effects across all post-treatment periods using a doubly robust Callaway and Sant'Anna estimator with never-treated counties as the control group and state as a covariate. This estimator allows for heterogeneous treatment effects across cohorts and time periods. Bootstrapped standard errors are constructed using 1,000 iterations.

Table A.14 shows the results of matching estimators similar to those used for the left panel of Figure 2, with matching conducted on three periods of pre-treatment history. I exact-match on state and principal party control history and use nearest neighbor Mahalanobis

Figure A.8: **Effect of Principal Party Change on Election Administration - Callaway and Sant'Anna (2021)**. This shows four event-study plots using the dynamic doubly robust Callaway and Sant'Anna (2021) difference-in-differences estimator: the effect of a transition in principal party control on voter turnout (top left), residual vote (top right), provisional rate (bottom left), and absentee rejection rate (bottom right). The first party transition in the panel is used as the treatment. Results are relative to the biennial period prior to treatment (-1). 95% bootstrapped confidence intervals are shown.



distance matching on the outcome variable. I report the pooled ATT effect of a change in principal party control across years analyzed, 95% bootstrapped confidence intervals, the mean outcome, and the number of matched counties used for each regression. Although the sample sizes are small given the strict matching procedure, all point estimates are near zero and all confidence intervals include zero. The estimated effects are substantively small relative to the outcome means.

Table A.14: Pooled Matched ATT Estimates Of Election Administration Outcomes

Outcome	Pooled ATT	95% CI	Outcome Mean	N Pairs
Voter Turnout	0.003	[-0.014, 0.019]	0.547	88
Residual Vote Rate	0.001	[-0.000, 0.002]	0.010	16
Provisional Ballot Rate	0.001	[-0.001, 0.003]	0.010	40
Absentee Rejection Rate	0.004	[-0.006, 0.035]	0.018	48